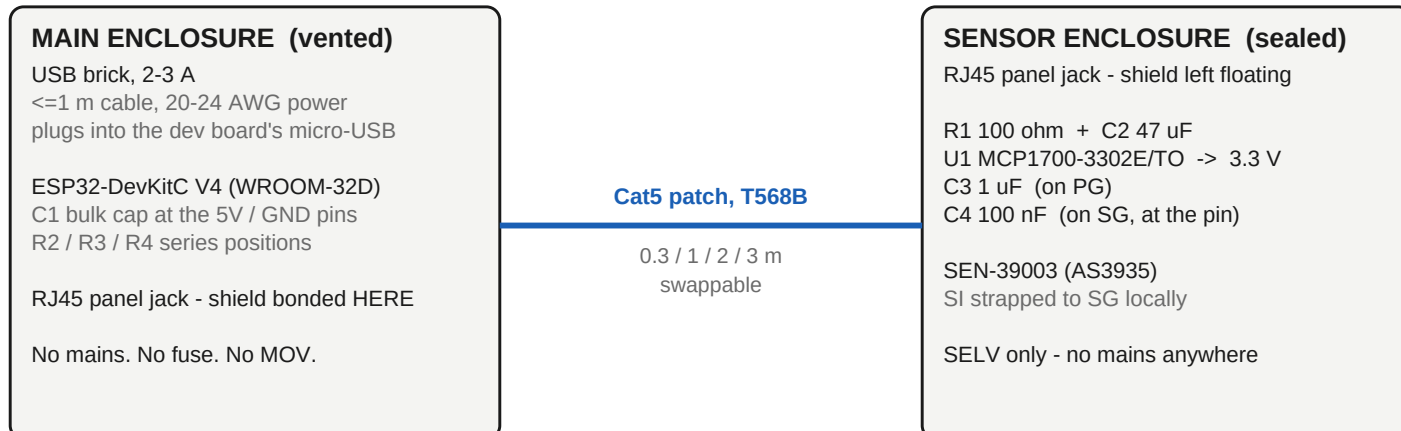


1. System overview

AS3935 lightning detector node - revision 2

Two enclosures. The patch cable length is a variable to be measured, not a fixed design choice - see README section 16.



Why two boxes

Near-field magnetic coupling falls as $1/r^3$, so 5 cm -> 50 cm is roughly a 1000x reduction. Distance is the strongest lever available and nothing else is close. The interference source was never identified (README 11.3), so the separation is left adjustable on purpose: survey at each cable length and read the curve. A flat curve eliminates the ESP32 and the supply properly for the first time.

Do not plug this into a network switch

The RJ45 carries 5 V and SPI, not Ethernet. A live PoE port puts 48 V on those lines and destroys the ESP32 and the sensor. Label both ends.

Signal assignment

T568B at both ends. Pairs are (1,2) (3,6) (4,5) (7,8). Seven signals plus one spare, and the spare is spent on a second ground paired with SCLK so the fastest edge gets its own return. SI is not carried - it straps to ground inside the sensor box.

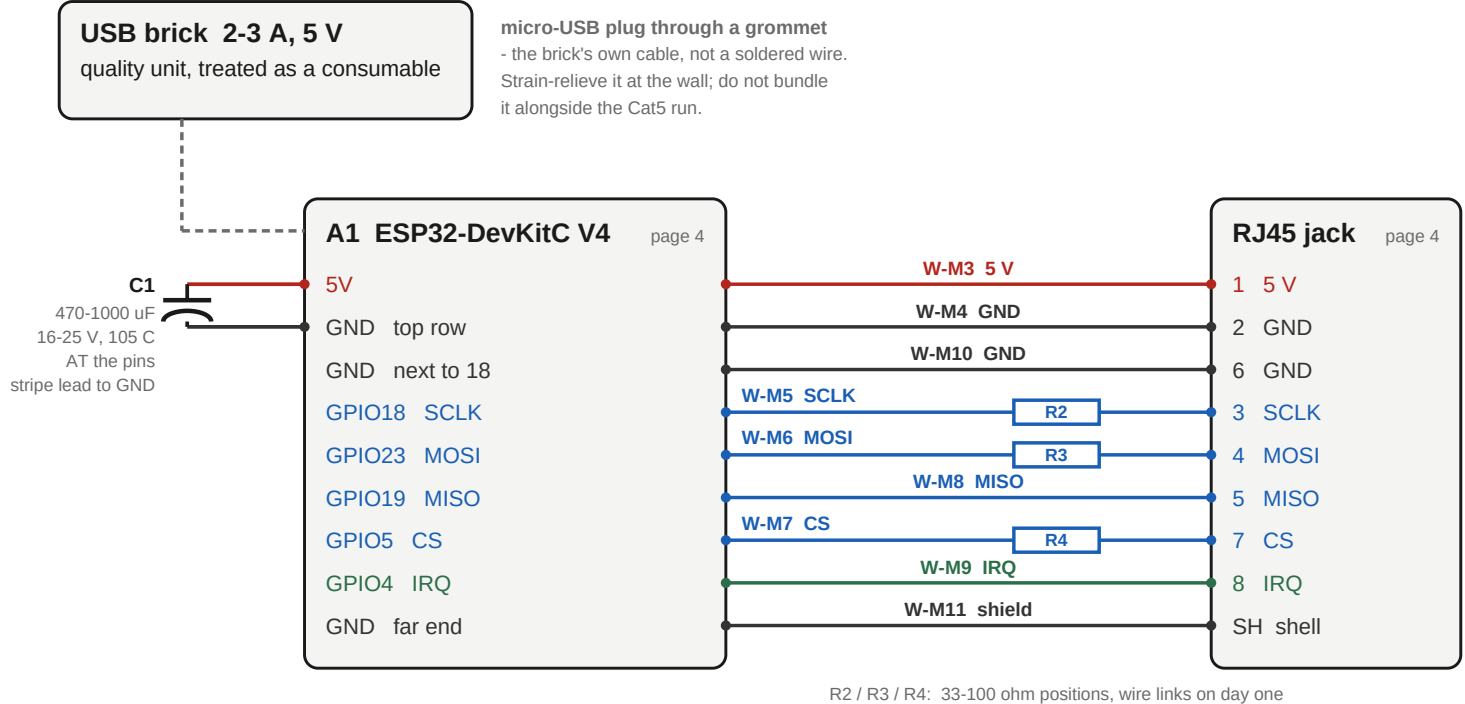
The jack has a ninth pin

The panel breakouts are shielded jacks on a 9-way 0.1 in header: 1-8 plus SH, the metal shell. SH is bonded to ground at the MAIN board only and left floating at the sensor. One end only - bonding both would wrap a ground loop around the whole run if a shielded patch cable were ever fitted. Pinout and orientation: page 4.

2. Main enclosure

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USB supply, ESP32, series positions and the RJ45 jack. Every line is one physical wire.



R2 / R3 / R4 - series positions, wire links on day one

Only the three lines the ESP32 DRIVES get a position: SCLK, MOSI, CS. MISO and IRQ are driven from the far end, so damping them at this end would do nothing at all. Fit plain wire links first. Set data_rate: 200kHz (README 7.1) and only fit real resistors if the 3 m point of the distance sweep misbehaves.

C1 is the reason this board exists

It is the reservoir for the 300-500 mA WiFi bursts the USB cable's resistance cannot supply fast enough. It must sit AT the 5V and GND pins. The DevKitC has five pins between 5V and its nearest ground, so the loop is about 27 mm however you arrange it - that is a property of the dev board, not of the layout. Watch the polarity.

The USB cable is a circuit element, not an accessory

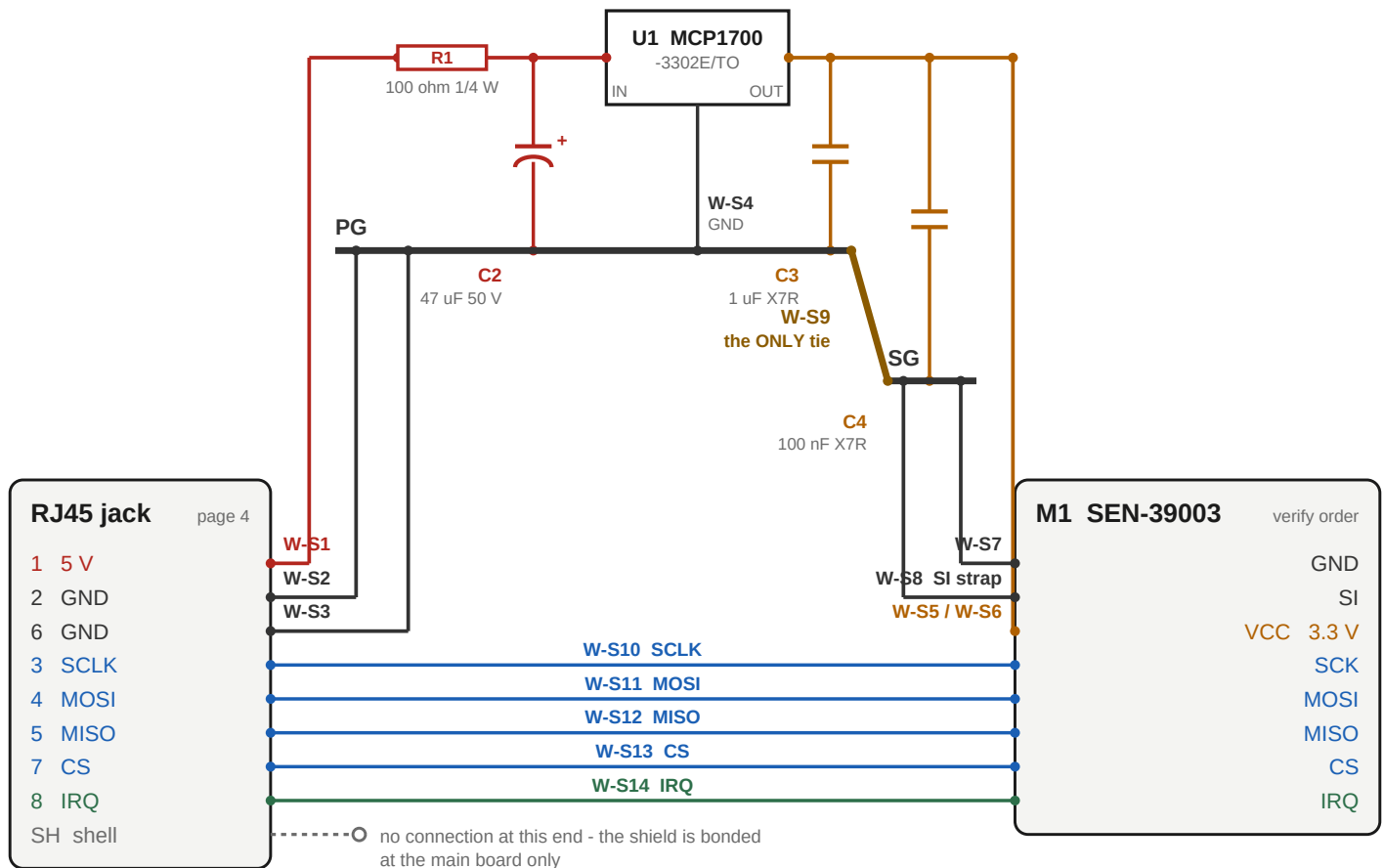
28 AWG conductors are ~0.21 ohm/m. Over 2 m, counting the ground return, that is ~0.84 ohm: a 500 mA burst drops ~0.42 V, so 5.0 V arrives as 4.58 V. The onboard AMS1117 needs over a volt of headroom, so a thin or long cable browns the board out - the same failure the undersized IRM-02-5 produced, by a different route.

Use <=1 m with 20-24 AWG power conductors, and MEASURE at the 5V pin under WiFi load. Keep the USB cable away from the Cat5 run; do not bundle them parallel.

3. Sensor enclosure

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Every part of the local rail, drawn. 5 V arrives on the cable; 3.3 V is made here, centimetres from the pins.



Two grounds, and exactly one tie between them

PG carries the cable's ground return, C2, and the regulator's own reference. SG carries only the sensor's GND pin, C4 and the SI strap. They meet at W-S9 and nowhere else. C3 belongs to the regulator (stability) so it lands on PG; C4 belongs to the sensor (decoupling) so it lands on SG. Swapping them defeats the split as surely as a second tie. A second bridge wraps a ground loop around the LDO and C4 stops being local.

Why a linear regulator, and why out here

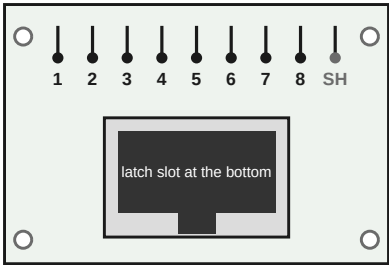
A switching regulator would put a 100 kHz - 1 MHz noise source centimetres from a 500 kHz magnetic antenna: the worst possible place for one. A linear regulator has no switching node, and at under 1 mA the wasted heat is nothing. The E suffix is the -40/+125 C grade, required for a ~52 C attic. C3 is REQUIRED for MCP1700 stability, not optional. LDO rejection is largely gone by 500 kHz, so R1/C2 and C3/C4 are complementary to it, not redundant with it. Neither the regulator nor the passives suffices alone.

Headroom check

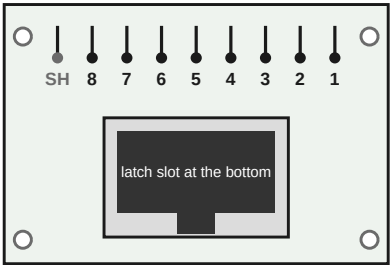
5 V leaves the main board from the dev board's 5V pin, which on some DevKitC boards sits behind a Schottky and reads ~0.3 V low. R1 drops another ~0.1 V at the sensor's sub-1 mA draw. Worst case the MCP1700 still sees ~4.5 V for a 3.3 V output - enormous headroom. Measure it anyway at bring-up: 3.3 V at the sensor VCC pin, at the far end (README 12).

4. Connector and board pinouts

The two parts this design is most likely to be wired backwards to. Wire to the printed numbers, never to a position in a photograph.



From INSIDE the box
the silkscreen side, where you solder



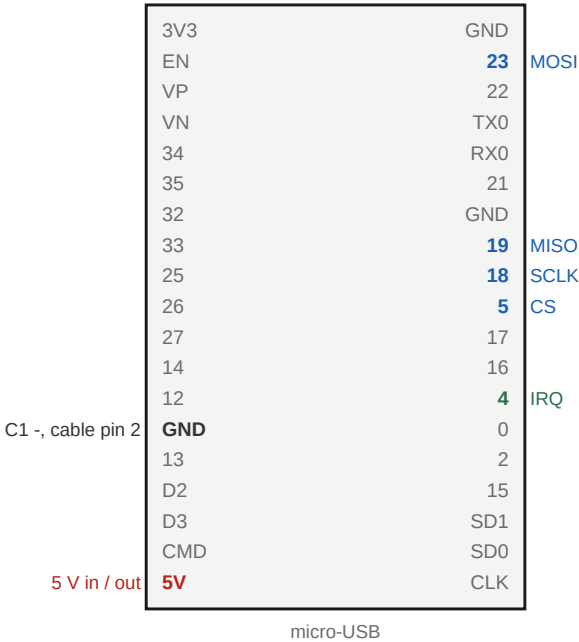
From OUTSIDE the box
looking into the jack, ready to plug in

Both drawings are the same part. You solder from the inside, so the silkscreen order 1..8, SH is the one that matters; the mirrored order is only what you see when you plug a cable in from outside.
9-way 0.1 in header, 2.54 mm pitch. PCB 33.86 x 27.96 mm, 1.4 mm thick. Mounting holes 3.00 mm in from each side, 28.00 mm apart - use the breakout itself as the drill template rather than trusting a dimension.

Pin	Signal	T568B colour	Note
1	5 V	white/orange	
2	GND	orange	
3	SCLK	white/green	
4	MOSI	blue	
5	MISO	white/blue	
6	GND	green	
7	CS	white/brown	
8	IRQ	brown	
SH	shield	(jack shell)	bonded to GND at the main board only

The jack is top-entry: the cable goes in PERPENDICULAR to the breakout PCB, so the board lies flat against the inside of the box wall behind a ~17 x 16.5 mm cutout and the right-angle header exits sideways. Solder the pigtail to the header pins, or pull the header and solder into its holes - lower profile and mechanically better. Cable-tie the bundle to the perf board.

A1 ESP32-DevKitC V4 / ESP32-WROOM-32D - 38 pins, USB at the bottom



Measured off the board in the vendor pinout: 19 pins per row, rows 1.0 in (25.4 mm) apart - exactly 10 holes on 0.1 in perf. Confirm yours before soldering the female headers, and use the dev board itself as the jig.

Note the vendor's own diagram mislabels left pin 10: the silkscreen reads 26, not 23. GPIO23 is on the RIGHT row. If you wire MOSI to the left row you will get nothing and see nothing wrong.

GPIO 4, 5, 18, 19 and 23 are ALL on the right row, so the whole cable pigtail lands on one side and only the 5 V feed crosses the board.

5V is the bottom-left pin, beside the USB. Its nearest ground is five pins away - see page 2.

5. Wire schedule

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Reference numbers match pages 2 and 3, and the hole coordinates in as3935-protoboard-layout.pdf.

Ref	From	To	AWG	Colour	Note
W-M1	C1 +	ESP32 5V pin	22 solid	red	as short as physically possible
W-M2	C1 -	ESP32 GND, top row	22 solid	black	with W-M1; stripe lead is minus
W-M3	C1 +	RJ45 pin 1	24 solid	wh/orange	twist with W-M4
W-M4	C1 -	RJ45 pin 2	24 solid	orange	the pin-1 pair's return
W-M5	ESP32 GPIO18 SCLK	R2, then RJ45 pin 3	24 solid	wh/green	series position
W-M6	ESP32 GPIO23 MOSI	R3, then RJ45 pin 4	24 solid	blue	series position
W-M7	ESP32 GPIO5 CS	R4, then RJ45 pin 7	24 solid	wh/brown	series position
W-M8	ESP32 GPIO19 MISO	RJ45 pin 5	24 solid	wh/blue	no resistor - MISO is an input here
W-M9	ESP32 GPIO4 IRQ	RJ45 pin 8	24 solid	brown	no resistor - IRQ is an input here
W-M10	ESP32 GND beside 18	RJ45 pin 6	24 solid	green	the SCLK pair's own return
W-M11	ESP32 GND, far end	RJ45 pin SH	24 solid	any	shield bonded at THIS end only
W-S1	RJ45 pin 1	R1 100 ohm	24 solid	wh/orange	start of the local rail
W-S2	RJ45 pin 2	PG rail	24 solid	orange	
W-S3	RJ45 pin 6	PG rail	24 solid	green	the SCLK pair's return
W-S4	U1 GND pin	PG rail	24 solid	black	
W-S5	U1 OUT 3.3 V	C4 + / VCC node	24 solid	red	
W-S6	C4 + node	sensor VCC	24 solid	red	one hole - do not lengthen
W-S7	sensor GND	SG rail	24 solid	black	
W-S8	sensor SI	SG rail	24 solid	black	grounds SI: selects SPI, not I2C
W-S9	SG rail	PG rail	22 solid	black	THE ONLY TIE - mark it
W-S10	RJ45 pin 3	sensor SCK	24 solid	wh/green	
W-S11	RJ45 pin 4	sensor MOSI	24 solid	blue	
W-S12	RJ45 pin 5	sensor MISO	24 solid	wh/blue	
W-S13	RJ45 pin 7	sensor CS	24 solid	wh/brown	
W-S14	RJ45 pin 8	sensor IRQ	24 solid	brown	
-	RJ45 pin SH (sensor)	nothing	-	-	left floating: single-point shield

Nothing here is carrying any current worth the name

Past the RJ45 the whole sensor rail draws under 1 mA. The longest run on either board is about 90 mm; even 30 AWG would add 30 milliohms, or 15 microvolts at 500 uA. R1 drops 0.1 V on purpose - six thousand times more. Gauge is electrically irrelevant on both boards. It is chosen on mechanical grounds alone, and page 6 says why.

The one place gauge ever mattered in this project is the USB cable (README 7.4), and that is a cable you buy, not one you build.

Colour is documentation, so keep it

The colour column is T568B, because the pigtails are cut from Cat5: the conductor colours then match the pin numbers on both breakouts and the cable between them, end to end, with nothing to remember. Where a wire is not part of the cable run (W-M1, W-M2, W-S4, W-S7, W-S8, W-S9) use plain red for 5 V, orange for 3.3 V, black for ground.

6. Wire specification, and bring-up

AS3935 lightning detector node - revision 2

What to buy, what not to use, and the order to switch things on in.

What each job actually needs

Where	What	Length	Why
Buses on the sensor board	bare SOLID tinned copper, 20-22 AWG	~1 m	must lie straight across the pads
Links on both boards	insulated SOLID, 24 AWG (26 also fine)	~2 m	must enter a 1 mm hole unaided
Pigtails, jack to board	solid Cat5e offcut, 8 cores	2 x 15 cm	colours match the pin table exactly
USB brick to ESP32	none - it plugs into the micro-USB	-	grommet and strain relief only
Mains variant (README 7.3)	stranded silicone, 18-20 AWG	-	not built in rev 2

Shopping list

Item	Specification	Qty	Note
Bus wire	bare solid tinned copper, 22 AWG, ~0.64 mm	1 spool	sold as 'buss bar wire' / 'jumper wire'
Hookup wire	solid core, 24 AWG, PVC or PTFE, 6 colours	1 kit	PTFE if you can: it will not melt back
Cat5e offcut	SOLID conductor cable, ~1 m	1	riser/in-wall stock, NOT a patch cable
Female header	0.1 in, 1x40 breakaway	2	cut to 1x19 for the ESP32
Male header	0.1 in, 1x40 breakaway	1	8 pins for the SEN-39003, if not supplied

Why not the silicone stranded already on hand

16 / 18 / 20 / 24 AWG stranded silicone is excellent wire and the wrong wire for this. Stranded will not enter a 0.1 in hole without being tinned first, and a tinned end is a solid end with worse geometry. Silicone insulation is thick and soft, so at 2.54 mm pitch it crowds neighbouring holes and will not hold a route. And a bus has to be a straight bare bar soldered to eight pads in a row: stranded cannot be made straight. Keep it for the mains variant and for anything that has to flex.

Why solid Cat5e for the pigtails

Eight solid 24 AWG conductors in one jacket, already coloured to T568B, so the pigtail documents itself against the pin table on page 4. Do not cut up one of the patch cables bought for the distance sweep - those are the experiment. Buy a metre of in-wall stock, or salvage a dead cable, and check it is SOLID: patch cable is stranded. Its insulation is usually HDPE and shrinks back fast under an iron. Strip generously, tin quickly, do not dwell. Leave a service loop and cable-tie both ends to the board. SH has no conductor in the cable, so it is a ninth wire: any offcut will do.

Not 30 AWG wire-wrap, tempting as it is

Kynar wire-wrap is the classic perfboard wire and it is genuinely nicer to route. It is also fragile, and README 11.3 is this project's warning about builds that move: the old breadboard's noise floor fell by two thirds the moment it was handled. Rigidity is a pass/fail measurement here, so spend the extra bulk on 24 AWG solid.

Bring-up, in order

1. Assemble both boxes; connect with the SHORTEST patch cable.
2. Measure 5 V at the ESP32 5V pin DURING WiFi activity, not at idle. Want >4.7 V.
3. Measure 3.3 V at the sensor VCC pin, at the far end, after the LDO.
4. Verify tuning capacitance OVER SERIAL - the one check WiFi cannot do (README 12.1).
5. Confirm the sensor responds to the SEN-39002 emulator. Expect disturbers, not lightning.
6. Platform-validity test: survey, handle the build, survey again. Rates must not move.
7. Only then mount, and run the distance sweep at 0.3 / 1 / 2 / 3 m.